

TRINH PHAM

KDI School of Public Policy and Management
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EMPLOYMENT

Assistant Professor, KDI School of Public Policy and Management, August 2024 – present

EDUCATION

Ph.D. Applied Economics and Management, Cornell University, May 2024

Dissertation Title: “Essays in Development and Environmental Economics”

Dissertation Committee: Christopher B. Barrett, John F. Hoddinott, Ariel Ortiz-Bobea

M.P.P. Regional Development and Environment, KDI School of Public Policy and Management, 2017

Summa Cum Laude, Salutatorian

Minor in Sustainable Development

B.Ec. International Economic Relations, Vietnam National University Ho Chi Minh City, 2015

Honours with Distinction

PEER-REVIEWED PUBLICATIONS

1. “[Mentoring, Educational Preferences, and Career Choices: Evidence from Two Field Experiments in Bhutan.](#)” (2025). *Journal of Policy Analysis and Management*, with Ryotaro Hayashi, Hyuncheol Bryant Kim and Norihiko Matsuda.
2. “[Structural Transformation, Agriculture, Climate, and the Environment.](#)” (2023). *Review of Environmental Economics and Policy*, Vol 17, No 2, with Christopher B. Barrett and Ariel Ortiz-Bobea.
3. “[The Child Education and Health Ethnic Inequality Consequences of Climate Shocks in Vietnam.](#)” (2022). *Economics of Education Review*, Vol 90, 102311.
4. “[The Intertemporal Evolution of Agriculture and Labor over a Rapid Structural Transformation: Lessons from Vietnam.](#)” (2020). *Food Policy*, Vol 94, 101913, with Yanyan Liu, Christopher B. Barrett, and William Violette.

WORKING PAPERS

1. “[Temperature Shocks, Worker Age, and Sectoral Reallocation into Informality: Evidence from Vietnam](#)” (*Revision Requested, Journal of Development Economics*)

A previous version was circulated as “Climate Change and Intersectoral Labor Reallocation in a Developing Country” – Distinguished PhD Research Paper Award by the Weiss Fund for Research in Development Economics (NEUDC 2023, Harvard Kennedy School)

Abstract: Do climate shocks push agricultural workers into formal or informal employment? Using three decades of Vietnamese survey and weather data, I show that extreme heat drives workers out of agriculture and into informal employment across all age groups, but only younger workers also enter formal employment. A three-sector Roy model links these patterns to temperature-driven declines in agricultural returns, with agricultural attachment and age-varying formal-sector barriers determining who exits and where they go. Supporting evidence confirms both channels: heat reduces yields and farm revenue without price adjustments, while job postings and a vignette experiment document age-based barriers in formal hiring.

2. [“Who Benefits from Place-Based Industrial Policies? Labor Market Adjustments and Household Welfare in Vietnam”](#)

Abstract: Governments routinely evaluate place-based policies by measuring their effects on formal employment and registered firms. But in settings where most workers earn their livelihoods outside the formal sector, this approach may understate total benefits and mischaracterize who gains. This paper examines this question in the context of industrial zones in Vietnam. To guide the empirical analysis, I develop a model of segmented local labor markets in which formal employment expands but remains constrained for less-educated workers. The model predicts that higher formal earnings raise demand for locally produced non-tradable goods and services, increasing returns to informal activities through an indirect local demand channel. Using nationally representative household survey data from 2002 to 2020 and a staggered difference-in-differences design, I find strong support for these predictions: less-educated households reallocate labor from agriculture toward informal services, increase labor diversification, and raise total income. Informal non-farm income accounts for three-quarters of their non-farm income gains, driven by non-tradable business formation. These gains translate into higher consumption and increased investment in children’s schooling. Assessments based solely on formal employment would capture only a quarter of the income gains for less-educated households, substantially understating the welfare impact of industrial zones.

3. [The Environmental Cost of Place-Based Industrial Policy: Evidence from Industrial Zones in Vietnam](#)

Abstract: This paper evaluates the environmental impacts of industrial zones in Vietnam. Exploiting the staggered establishment of over 300 zones in the last two decades, I first show that their operation roughly doubles satellite-detected industrial combustion within 5km of the centroids. Using wind-driven variation in downwind exposure to distinguish the zones’ downwind contribution from background pollution, I then find that zone operation raises ambient PM_{2.5} for nearby populations by $0.70 \mu\text{g}/\text{m}^3$, implying a 25-day loss of life expectancy per exposed person. This effect is not fixed: it is largest in a zone’s early years, attenuates with age, and is indistinguishable from zero for the most recent cohort. A scale-composition-technique decomposition attributes the variation to a shift in the sectoral mix toward lighter manufacturing, rather than to cleaner production within firms or larger scale, unlike the technique-driven emission reductions documented in advanced economies. These findings suggest that where enforcement is weak, the pollution a zone generates depends mainly on the industries it attracts.

4. [“Place-based Industrial Policies and Intergenerational Educational Inequality: Evidence from Vietnam”](#)

Abstract: Intergenerational educational inequality remains substantial in many countries. This paper studies whether place-based industrialization can reduce the intergenerational transmission of educational disadvantage. Using Vietnam’s expansion of industrial zones and household survey

data, I implement a staggered difference-in-differences design comparing individuals differentially exposed to zone openings. Industrial zones increase school enrollment among 15–18-year-olds, with effects concentrated among children whose parents did not complete upper-secondary school, narrowing enrollment gaps by parental education. Mechanism evidence points to household income as the primary channel: less-educated households gain income from informal non-agricultural activities—local demand spillovers rather than direct zone employment.

SELECTED WORK-IN-PROGRESS

1. “The Psychological Cost of High-Stakes Exams: Evidence from South Korea,” with Jinseong Park

Abstract: High-stakes college entrance exams determine educational trajectories for millions of students worldwide, yet little is known about their psychological consequences. This paper exploits quasi-random variation in tier assignment on South Korea’s national college entrance exam using a regression discontinuity design. Falling just below a tier cutoff increases academic stress by 0.2 standard deviations, driven by heightened concerns about college admissions prospects. Students below the cutoff also report a higher likelihood of having seriously considered suicide. We find no effect on non-academic stress, indicating that the psychological impact is concentrated in the exam-relevant domain. Despite being more likely to retake the exam, students below the cutoff show no significant improvement in university placement over the next five years, or labor market outcomes in the next ten years. These findings provide new causal evidence that discrete score thresholds in high-stakes exams generate domain-specific psychological costs that are not offset by measurable gains in university quality or labor market outcomes.

2. “Motivational Framing and Work-Place Conflicts: Experimental Evidence from Vietnamese Industrial Parks,” with Changkeun Lee and David Sungho Park

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

† denotes Master’s level courses, * denotes PhD-level courses

KDI School

Environmental Economics in Developing Countries†, Spring 2025–2026

Introduction to Development Policy†, Spring 2025–2026, Fall 2025

Development Economics*, Fall 2024–2025

Cornell University

TA, Applied Econometrics†, Professor Brian Dillon, Fall 2021/2023

Co-instructor, Math and Statistics camp for incoming Master’s students, Summer 2022

TA, Economics of Developing Countries, Professor Brian Dillon, Spring 2021/2022

TA, Research and Methods†, Professors Mark Conostas and Aija Leiponen, Fall 2020

TA, Risk Simulation and Monte Carlo Methods†, Professor Calum Turvey, Spring 2020

TA, Introduction to Economics of Development, Professor Steven Kyle, Fall 2019

HONORS, AWARDS & FELLOWSHIPS

Agricultural and Applied Economics Association (AAEA), *Outstanding Doctoral Dissertation Award* 2025

Cornell Dyson School of Applied Economics and Management, *Best PhD Dissertation Award* 2025

JPAL Learning for All Initiative, *Proposal Development Grant*, with Maulik Jagnani

KDI School, *Research Grant*

The Weiss Fund for Research in Development Economics, *Weiss Family Distinguished PhD Research Paper Award at NEUDC 2023*, Harvard Kennedy School

Cornell Dyson School of Applied Economics and Management, *George F. Warren Award First Place* 2024

Cornell University, *Graduate School Fellowship Spring 2024*, *Conference Travel Grant 2021-2023*

KDI School, *Outstanding Thesis & Academic Excellence 2016*, *Global Ambassador Scholarship 2015-2016*

Vietnam National University Ho Chi Minh City, *Student of Five Merits 2014*, *University of Economics and Law Dean's List 2011-2015*

Rencontres du Vietnam Odon Vallet Scholarship 2015, POSCO Asia Fellowship 2014, American Chamber of Commerce in Ho Chi Minh City Scholarship 2014

PROFESSIONAL ACTIVITIES

Conference, Workshop, and Seminar Presentations (*including scheduled*, * presented by co-authors)

2026: Asia Meeting of the Econometric Society

2025: Korea Institute for International Economic Policy, Asian Economic Development Conference*, National Cheng Kung University, KDI School - World Bank DIME Conference, NEUDC

2024: University of Melbourne, Taipei School of Economics and Political Science, KDI School - World Bank DIME Conference, Asian & Australasian Society of Labour Economics Conference

2023: Midwest International Economic Development Conference, Climate Economics Pipeline Workshop (Harvard Kennedy School), AAEA, LSE Environment Week (London School of Economics), Development Workshop (Cornell University), NEUDC, Applied Economics and Policy Seminar Series (Cornell University), KDI School

2021: Agricultural & Applied Economics Association Annual Meeting (online)

Journal Referee Service

American Journal of Agricultural Economics, Education Economics, Economic Modeling, Economics of Education Review, Food Policy, International Journal of Educational Development, Journal of Development Economics, Journal of Development Studies, Plos One

Other Service

Application Reviewer and Co-Mentor for STAARS Fellows Program, 2020/2021

Reviewer for Jobs and Development Conference 2024

Organizing Committee, KDI School - World Bank DIME Conference 2024–2026

OTHER EXPERIENCE

World Bank Group, Short-term Consultant, April 2022-June 2022

Project “Meta-analytic Reviews of Literature on Climate Change and Human Capital”

Asian Development Bank, Short-term Consultant, April 2021-March 2022

Project “Impact Evaluation for Skills Training and Education Pathways Upgradation”

Cornell University, RA for Professor Christopher B. Barrett, 2018-2020

KDI School of Public Policy and Management, RA for Professor Booyuel Kim, 2017-2018

VNU-Hanoi Institute for Economic and Policy Research, Researcher, 2016-2018

Project “Labor Productivity and Wage Growth in Vietnam”

Project “Development Characteristics of SME Sector in Vietnam: Evidence from the Vietnam Enterprise Census 2006-2015”

MISCELLANEOUS

Languages: Vietnamese (native), English (fluent), Korean (intermediate)